





the area around Calcutta. Examples from the area around Srinagar are made of metal, while those in the area around Mangalore are made from terracotta. The materials of the place also determine the patterns, and therefore the overall design of the element. The appellation can equally be applied to complete buildings; the Chettinad bungalows in Tamil Nadu, the circular mud enclosures of Kutch, and the houseboats of Kashmir all have instant recall within the community and are upheld as templates of climate-appropriate design. The Heritage Trust, INTACH, has conducted thousands of listings, documenting buildings in areas as diverse as Dundlod and Kapurthala. There are inevitable self-similarities to buildings made in a specific region and often from a particular era in history.

Design Defense

In the contemporary era, architects have often tried to create "different" or "signature" buildings. This inevitably means departing from the norm, the traditional and the locally prized. However, there are recent examples of buildings that strongly reflect the idea that they can only belong to a particular place and time. The remarkable collection of institutional buildings designed by Joseph Stein around the Lodhi Gardens around 50 years ago is distinctive for its use of local materials and self-similarity. In a similar vein, the architecture of contemporary buildings around the Central Vista carry the signature combination of yellow and red sandstone, with imposing circular columns and raised plinths. In Bombay, the art deco "mansions" along Marine Drive have been partially lost to apathy. However, there are several stunning examples of the signature swooping balconies and florid surface patterns still to be seen. It can almost be said that some buildings are so spectacular that no one dares to destroy them. Perhaps that is the way some buildings endure for centuries. But endurance alone is not legacy. Legacy requires that a building's story be known—not just by architects and historians, but by the city that lives around it. GI mapping offers precisely this: a publicly legible record of why a building exists, what it is made of, and what it means.

The question of how a GI sign functions is often a matter of local law and user perception. Historically, there has been a link between the traditions and materials of a place and the appearance of the local buildings. That link has been eroded with globalisation, where overconsumption has created a culture of agglomeration—the act of bringing together things from around the world to create a unique product. We now know this to be a deeply flawed approach. It is important to distinguish between GI and an appellation of origin. While a single essential quality (like the laterite stones of Goa) may be enough for a GI sign, an appel-